OTHER WARRIORS OF THE VIKING ERA

Viking raids and settlement were just one element in a period of widespread insecurity throughout Europe and the Mediterranean zone after the splintering of the Western Roman Empire. By the 7th century even the Byzantine successors of Rome in the east were not wealthy enough to pay and equip a large standing army. The Anglo-Saxons were not unusual in relying upon a small band of full-time warriors supported by a much larger number of self-equipped levies – men forced into service. In the 8th and 9th centuries the Franks created a substantial, if fragile, empire in western Europe through the effectiveness of their heavy cavalry, but it was the Normans, French-speaking descendants of the Vikings, who proved the most formidable fighters of the era.

THE ANGLO-SAXONS

Taking over control of England from the 5th century CE, the Anglo-Saxon rulers initially led personal warbands in the Germanic tradition. By the time King Alfred (ruled 871–899) was fighting the Danes, he was leading an army of levies, known as the "fyrd". They were raised on a regional basis. A local nobleman or "thegn" was obliged to present himself when required with the appropriate number of men drawn from among the lower ranks of the free population. They had to come equipped with basic armour and a weapon. The fyrd not only supplied troops for the king to lead in battle but also maintained and manned fortified "burghs" as centres of local defence. In the 11th century Anglo-Saxon kings also had a standing professional force of "housecarls" – a system copied from the Danes. Funded from taxation, these formidable fighters acted as the king's escort and companions, and were the core of his army in battle.

Most Anglo-Saxon soldiers travelled on horseback, but they always dismounted to fight. The housecarls were armed with swords or with formidable two-handed axes – originally a Viking weapon. Most of the fyrd carried spears, the easiest weapon for a local blacksmith to make and the simplest for an untrained man to use. Archers formed a normal part of Anglo-Saxon forces, although few were present at the battle of Hastings in 1066. On the battlefield, the Anglo-Saxons stood in tight formation, creating a shield wall. Housecarls, who were often protected by a shield-bearer and a spearman, could chop down a horse with a single blow of their two-handed axes. Facing the Norman mounted knights near the village of Hastings, the Anglo-Saxons were still very effective fighters despite being exhausted from the long march south from Yorkshire, after defeating the Norwegian King Harald Hardrada. The result of the battle could easily have gone the other way.

Last stand
A scene from the Bayeux Tapestry shows Anglo-Saxon housecarls, clad in chainmail "byrnies", desperately resisting a Norman cavalry charge at the battle of Hastings in 1066.

